Happiness

Hello everyone, and welcome! This is the third episode of the Cottongue Podcast.

[00:00:10] I hope everything is going well where you are and that you're enjoying spring!

[00:00:15] If you haven't listened to the previous episodes, I'm going to explain why I make this podcast.

[00:00:23] My name is Hugo, and I'm a French teacher in Poland, in Warsaw. Since I've been living in Poland for three years, I'm learning Polish. And for learning a foreign language, I find that podcasts are a very good tool, a very good method. But the problem with these podcasts is that they're often boring. They don't discuss interesting subjects. People think that because listeners don't understand everything, we cannot talk to them about original topics. Well, I'm going to talk to you about things I find interesting, and I hope you'll enjoy them.

[00:01:10] In this podcast, we're not going to study grammar. If you want to study grammar, there are lots of websites and books for that. Here, you just need to listen and try to understand what I'm telling you. I recommend listening to this podcast several times so you can understand more and more things. At first, it's normal not to understand everything. You need several listens to understand everything I say, or to try to understand a large part of what I'm telling you.

[00:01:55] Here in Warsaw, today is a public holiday. A public holiday is a day when people don't work, to celebrate a national event. For example, today in Poland, we're celebrating the Constitution of 3 May 1791. The Polish Constitution is the oldest constitution in Europe and the second-oldest constitution in the world, after the Constitution of the United States. So today is a national holiday in Poland, a public holiday when nobody works.

[00:02:41] But I'm working, because I've decided to record a new podcast for you. And in this podcast, I'm not going to talk to you about the Polish Constitution, don't worry! Today, I want to talk to you about happiness.

[00:03:01] But first, we need to try to define happiness, to explain what it is.

[00:03:09] Happiness is a feeling we experience when we're completely satisfied. We also say that we're happy, that we feel good. For example, imagine it's summer, in July, or in August if you prefer August. You're on holiday in the south of France, and it's very hot. You're in a wonderful swimming pool with your friends, and you have no problems. You're having a fantastic holiday, the best holiday of your life. Everything is going well, and you're happy to be there at that precise moment. "Life is beautiful," as we say in French. Well, at that moment, we can say that you're experiencing happiness.

[00:04:09] When we think of happiness like that, it seems very simple. But in fact, it's a little more complicated than that. For example, there are hundreds of articles in magazines, on the internet and in newspapers about finding happiness. Readers are offered recipes for

being happy. They're offered the ingredients of happiness. There are even happiness specialists, and also a worldwide study called the World Happiness Report, which compares happiness levels in different countries, ranks countries and looks at which countries have the happiest people.

[00:05:08] Today, we're going to talk about this study. Do you want to know which countries have the happiest people? Then stay with me, and you'll know by the end of this podcast. I promise!

[00:05:24] Are you ready? Then here we go!

[00:05:32] First, we're going to talk a little about philosophy.

[00:05:37] The Greek philosophers were very interested in the idea of happiness. Philosophers, you know, are people who ask themselves questions and write about somewhat abstract ideas: morality, virtue, good, evil, desire, and so on. You surely know Socrates, Plato and Aristotle, for example. They are three of the most famous philosophers of ancient Greece. Unfortunately, even in ancient Greece, philosophers didn't agree on the definition of "happiness".

[00:06:23] However, they agreed on one point: happiness is the ultimate goal of human beings. That means people do everything to find it. The cause of all their actions is this search for happiness. For example, we work to earn money, and that money is supposed to make us happy. With this money, we can buy things that will make us happy: a house, a car, or a holiday. Another example: when you look for someone to share your life with, a husband or a wife, it's because you think you'll be happier with that person. So there you are: when we think about it, we understand that all our actions are motivated by the search for happiness. Happiness is the ultimate goal of human beings. The Greek philosophers agreed on that point.

[00:07:38] But behind happiness, there is also the idea of pleasure. Because pleasure comes from satisfying a desire or a need. For example, the pleasure of eating a delicious dish, your favourite dish, or the pleasure of seeing a friend you haven't seen for a long time. But be careful: sometimes pleasure can harm happiness. "To harm" is a verb that means "to be bad", "to do damage to someone or something". We say that cigarettes harm our health, that smoking is bad for our health.

[00:08:25] Why can pleasure harm happiness? Because it's often fleeting, temporary. You know very well that when we party and drink alcohol, for example, we have a good time and feel a little euphoric. But the day after, the following day, we feel bad. We have a headache, and we don't feel like doing anything. In French, this is called "avoir la gueule de bois", having a hangover. Having a hangover is when you drank too much alcohol the previous day, the day before, and you feel bad, have a headache and have no energy. In French, this is called "avoir la gueule de bois". So that's a good example. In the evening, you're happy and feel pleasure because you're drinking, because you're pleased to be with your friends and to be partying. But the next day, you regret your actions, your decisions, a little. So yes, pleasure sometimes harms happiness.

[00:09:40] That brings us to a third idea connected with happiness: the idea of stability. Happiness isn't being happy for five minutes, or even for five hours. Happiness is a stable, lasting state. That's what distinguishes happiness from pleasure. We can say that happiness is stable, constant pleasure, a state in which we feel completely satisfied. In French, we say "être comblé", to be completely fulfilled. Being completely fulfilled is when all your desires, all your wishes have come true. You don't want anything else, and you don't expect anything more. The philosopher Aristotle thought that only at the end of their life does a person know whether they have truly found happiness: when they look back, when they look at their life to see whether they have been happy.

[00:10:53] OK, so that was the philosophical part of happiness.

[00:11:00] Now I'm going to talk to you about the World Happiness Report. It's an annual report published by the United Nations, and it has existed since 2012. This year, in 2017, they have therefore published their fifth report. So how do you think researchers can measure a country's level of happiness? It's a little strange, isn't it, to measure the happiness level of its inhabitants?

[00:11:38] To do this, the researchers chose different criteria, different parameters: objective indicators and subjective criteria. For the subjective criteria, they interviewed, they asked questions of, 1,000 people in 150 different countries. They interviewed 1,000 people in each country. Using these inhabitants' answers, the researchers were able to assess their level of happiness.

[00:12:18] What do you think the criteria, the indicators, used to measure a country's level of happiness are? Do you have any idea?

[00:12:31] I'm going to help you a little.

[00:12:34] The first criterion is Gross Domestic Product per capita. Generally, we say GDP: Gross Domestic Product. GDP is a country's wealth, the wealth a country produces each year. And GDP per capita is this wealth divided by the number of inhabitants in the country. Logically, small, wealthy countries such as Luxembourg, Switzerland or Norway have a very big advantage here. GDP per capita is a very important indicator. It also means that we associate happiness with wealth. Yet in French, we have a proverb: "Money doesn't bring happiness." But sometimes we add, "but it contributes to it." "Money doesn't bring happiness, but it contributes to it." That means money isn't enough to be happy; we need other things. But money can help, it can help us be happy.

[00:14:00] The second criterion is life expectancy. Life expectancy is the average lifespan of a population, of a generation. In France, life expectancy is 82 years. That means babies currently being born in France will statistically live to the age of 82. Of course, it's only a statistic. If a country has a high life expectancy, it probably has a good healthcare system to treat sick people, lots of hospitals and clinics. Thanks to all that, thanks to that infrastructure, to that healthcare system, its inhabitants are healthy. If they're healthy, they'll live longer. And logically, it's easier to be happy when you're healthy. Do you know which countries have the highest life expectancy? Well, the three countries with the highest life expectancy in the world are Japan, Switzerland and Singapore.

[00:15:26] The third criterion of the World Happiness Report is social support. Social support means that you have someone to rely on when you have a problem: your parents, your partner, your friends. Again, that's logical, isn't it? We feel more secure when we know there are people to help us if we have a problem. In French, we say "se serrer les coudes", to stick together. "Se serrer les coudes" means helping one another, showing solidarity. If a family member or a friend has financial problems, for example, you'll help them. Whereas if we don't feel secure, if we're afraid for our future, it's difficult to be happy. We find again the idea of stability, which we discussed a little earlier, and which is essential to happiness. The highest-ranked countries, where people show the most solidarity, are Iceland, Ireland and Denmark. France ranks 46th for this criterion. That means French people should make an effort to help one another more, to stick together more, to show more solidarity with one another.

[00:17:11] Next, there is the trust indicator, the fourth criterion. In French, we say "avoir confiance en quelqu'un" or "faire confiance à quelqu'un". There are two possibilities: "avoir confiance en quelqu'un", for example "j'ai confiance en lui", meaning "I have confidence in him"; or "faire confiance à quelqu'un", for example "je lui fais confiance", meaning "I trust him". Trusting someone means thinking that this person is honest and won't deceive you. In the happiness report, they ask inhabitants whether they trust their government and businesses. Inhabitants trust these institutions when there is no corruption, when the government does its job well and businesses aren't corrupt. When everyone has the same chances of succeeding. Indeed, it's difficult to feel good in a country when you cannot trust the system.

[00:18:29] Freedom is the fifth indicator used in this ranking. Freedom here means being able to make your own decisions, to make your own choices, when nobody forces you to make decisions against your will. If you want to change jobs, you can do it. If you want to move, to live in another city or another country, you can do it. If you want to get married or get divorced, you can do it. The opposite of this freedom is being in prison. When you're in prison, you have almost no freedom. Once again, it's rather logical. I don't think there are people who are happy to be in prison.

[00:19:31] The sixth and final criterion, the most interesting one in my opinion, is generosity. This generosity is measured through gifts and donations. In other words, when we give money to an organisation that helps people with disabilities, children, animals or any other cause. According to the ranking, the countries where people are most generous are Myanmar, Indonesia and Malta. It's interesting because I think being generous, thinking of others and trying to help them is something that makes us happy because we feel useful. It's very important to feel useful. But I'll talk about that a little later.

[00:20:34] With all these criteria, which countries do you think have the happiest people? Any idea?

[00:20:43] When we calculate the average of the different indicators, it's mainly the Scandinavian countries that come out on top. "To come out on top" means "to be first in a ranking". Norway is first, Denmark second, Iceland third, followed by Switzerland in fourth place and Finland in fifth place.

[00:21:13] And do you think your country is ranked highly? If you want to check, you can find your country's ranking on the internet by searching for the World Happiness Report 2017.

[00:21:33] So now we've seen that happiness is a lasting state in which we're satisfied, in which all our desires are fulfilled. But to reach this state, there are external conditions, conditions that don't depend on us, that depend, for example, on the country where we live.

[00:22:01] However, in Western countries, happiness has become an obsession, a selfish, narcissistic obsession. Everyone does everything to find it. Some journalists even talk about the "dictatorship of happiness".

[00:22:22] What does the "dictatorship of happiness" mean? It means this search for happiness is like a kind of tyranny. It requires people to live in a particular way if they want to be happy. In the media and advertisements, we're given orders on how to be happy: exercise, eat a balanced diet, go on holiday here or there, buy this car or this smartphone. We need to do a job we're passionate about and find the ideal wife or husband. All that is a little stressful, isn't it? Don't you think?

[00:23:08] After all, everyone has a different view of happiness, don't they? Perhaps the things that make me happy don't appeal to my neighbour. For example, I love cycling on Sundays when the weather is nice. That makes me happy. But there are also people who don't like cycling and prefer other activities such as, I don't know, meditation, running or going to the cinema. Or some people prefer going to the seaside for their holidays, and others to the mountains. It depends on people's tastes, their preferences!

[00:23:53] So how can "happiness experts" help us be happy?

[00:24:00] The most important thing, in my opinion, is learning to know yourself. "Know yourself," the Greek philosophers used to say. Everyone is different. We need to learn to appreciate our differences, our uniqueness, to know what makes us happy.

[00:24:22] If you try to imitate others, to copy their recipe for happiness, that will probably create frustration and jealousy. It might even make you unhappy. If you conform to the general definition of happiness that society gives, perhaps that won't work either. There are no universal ingredients that create happiness. Otherwise, we would know about them, and everyone would already be happy. On the contrary, you need to find your own recipe. Take time for yourself, to ask yourself questions, and find what really makes you happy. And above all, open yourself up to others. Don't simply seek your own personal happiness, but try to help other people find theirs. Happiness shouldn't be a selfish pleasure. It's something we should try to share as much as possible. It's a kind of wealth that can grow by being shared, unlike other kinds of wealth.

[00:25:46] So we're coming to the end of this podcast. I hope this subject of happiness has interested you. I hope you've learned new things, perhaps interesting things you'll want to discuss with your friends, with your family. And I also hope you'll want to listen to the next podcast.

[00:26:14] As usual, I encourage you to listen to this podcast several times. The more you listen to it, the more you'll understand. And to help you, you can also find the transcript of this podcast, meaning everything I've said, on my website, cottongue.com. Go to cottongue.com, to the podcast section, and if you register — it's free — you'll have access to all the transcripts of all the podcasts.

[00:26:57] Thank you, everyone, for listening to this podcast. I hope it has helped you learn French in a slightly different, perhaps slightly more entertaining way. Next week, for our new podcast, we'll talk about gender theory. So if you don't know what gender theory is, join me next week for the new podcast. In the meantime, try to do a little French every day, to read, listen to or watch interesting things, and we'll meet again next week. See you soon. Bye!